Rebecca: Understanding the Text

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Understanding the Text

All questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed personal response, which means that it is not enough just to know the text you are being examined on really well; you also need to develop a sound understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events in the novel you have studied, as well as an understanding of the significance of a particular moment or chapter in relation to the whole text. You also need to demonstrate an awareness of the text as a narrative piece. All of this will help you to develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text through which you are able to demonstrate individuality and insight.

Each of the sub-topics below will help you to develop a better understanding of the text:

- **Background information**
- **Narrative context**
- **Key moments in context**

Background information

A knowledge of the historical and social context of the novel can help you to develop an informed personal response. However, it is very important that you do not include lots of historical information about Daphne du Maurier and/or the time in which the novel was written in your answer. Your response to the text should be firstly based on the focus of the question and the key theme(s) the question prompts you to explore.

- Daphne du Maurier was born on 16th May 1907 in London, England:
  - Her father, Sir Gerald du Maurier, was a well-known actor and her mother, Muriel, was an actress
  - She was the second of three sisters and had a privileged upbringing in Hampstead
- The family bought a holiday home in Cornwall in the 1920s and it became du Maurier's favourite place of solitude:
  - Du Maurier's deep connection to Cornwall is evident in the novel's setting

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

would have been acquainted with the expectations and pressures associated with such a background:
    - This feeling of not fitting into the expected societal roles may have influenced the theme of displacement and the struggle for identity in Rebecca

- Du Maurier was often described as a romantic novelist:
    - This is somewhat misleading as she wrote dark and often gothic stories, with unexpected twists or suspenseful endings

- Rebecca was written and published in the late 1930s:
    - The novel explores class distinctions and social expectations prevalent in the early 20th century

- Du Maurier's experiences in the early 20th century, a time when expectations for women were evolving, could have influenced the feminist undertones in the narrative:
    - The novel explores the limitations placed on the protagonist by societal norms and the challenges she faced in asserting her individuality within the constraints of a patriarchal system
    - The novel reflects the evolving role of women in society and the protagonist's journey from a relatively ordinary background to the opulent and aristocratic world of Manderley
    - It symbolises the changing dynamics for women in terms of social mobility and expectations

- The 1930s saw a resurgence of interest in the Gothic literary tradition, where the past haunts the present:
    - Key Gothic elements are evident throughout the novel's characters and themes

- Du Maurier had a keen interest in psychology and the human mind:
    - This fascination is explored in the text through the novel's themes of identity, fear and insecurity

Help me understand

Narrative context

The literary context of a text can be thought of in terms of genre, as well as any ways that a text either conforms to or subverts the conventions of that genre. Rebecca contains elements of the Gothic, romantic and suspense genres but it also subverts these in many ways. This will be explored further below.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners like to see that students have an awareness of the form of a text, whether it's a novel, a play, a poem, etc. Rebecca is a **novel**, and so it's important that you signal to the examiner that you know this. This is as simple as using the term

The Gothic genre

- Although Rebecca contains no elements of the supernatural or an evil villain, it aligns to the Gothic genre in many ways:
  - This is largely evident through its focus on the present being haunted by the past
- Manderley also conforms to the Gothic tradition of using atmospheric settings to create mystery and suspense:
  - The mansion is shrouded in mystery, which creates a sense of foreboding and unease
- The spirit of Rebecca also adds an eerie atmosphere to the text:
  - Her haunting spirit remains firmly at Manderely and it has a direct influence on the events and characters within the novel
- Maxim embodies the brooding and mysterious male figure often found in Gothic texts:
  - Often these characters have a troubled past and hidden secrets
  - Maxim's haunted nature becomes apparent through his recurring nightmares and moments of introspection
- As a text, Rebecca also subverts the conventions of the Gothic genre
- The unnamed and unreliable narrator challenges the typical Gothic heroine:
  - Rather than being a passive victim, she undergoes significant character development:
    - This subverts the expectation of a helpless female character
- The destruction of Manderley also subverts the tradition of the Gothic house as a symbol of stability:
  - Its destruction by fire represents a purification and the emergence of truth
- Although Mrs Danvers appears as a classic Gothic **antagonist**, she is not a straightforward villain:
  - Her actions could be viewed as stemming from her grief and her inability to move on from the past

Romance and suspense genres

- At its core, the text has a romantic relationship between the unnamed narrator and Maxim de Winter:
  - This adheres to the typical romantic conventions of initial attraction, courtship and eventual marriage
- It is also not a traditional love story in that the ambiguity surrounding Maxim's feelings for Rebecca and the narrator's insecurity challenge the conventional element of an uncomplicated romantic narrative:
  - Maxim's haunted past contributes to the strained dynamics between him and the second Mrs de Winter

- The revelation of Rebecca's true nature and the tragic elements surrounding her death add tragedy to the narrative:
    - Rebecca lacks a traditional happy ending and the revelation of Maxim's secret and the destruction of Manderley subverts the typical resolution in romantic fiction

- The plot takes an excepted turn towards the end of the novel when legal proceedings become a central focus:
    - The outcome of the investigation into Rebecca's death becomes uncertain and raises questions about the fate of the characters

Key moments in context

It is not enough to just analyse a passage or chapter in isolation; you must also consider why that particular passage or chapter is important to the text as a whole. What key themes or ideas does it represent? Does it foreshadow upcoming events? Does it reveal more about a character's motivations, thoughts or feelings, given what has happened and/or what is to come? The following section includes some key moments from the novel and how they are relevant to the rest of the text, but this list is not exhaustive, and you are encouraged to consider other moments and how these also relate to the novel as a whole.

Key moment

Chapter 16
"Maxim had not moved. He stared up at me, his glass in his hand. There was no colour in his face. It was ashen white. I saw Frank go to him as though he would speak, but Maxim shook him off."

Summary of key moment:

- In this chapter, Maxim and the second Mrs de Winter host a costume ball
- The narrator follows Mrs Danvers's advice and unwittingly wears a dress similar to Rebecca's
- Maxim becomes incensed when he sees her

Why this is important in relation to the novel as a whole:

- The ball serves as a microcosm of the societal pressures and expectations that the protagonist faces:
    - The ball exposes the protagonist's insecurities and illustrates the contrast between her and Rebecca

- Her decision to follow Mrs Danvers's advice and dress similarly to the lady in the painting illustrates Mrs Danvers's sinister behaviour
- This moment is important as Maxim's failure to return to the narrator that night is seen to depict the ending of their marriage at this point in the novel

Key moment

stone like the little 'un.' He chuckled to himself, picking his nose. I did not say anything. 'The fishes have eaten her up by now, haven't they?' he said. 'Who?' I said."

Summary of key moment:

- In this chapter, Ben speaks about Rebecca's body and hints at the truth about Rebecca's death

Why this is important in relation to the novel as a whole:

- This incident in the chapter is the moment when the true circumstances surrounding Rebecca's death are revealed:
  - This revelation marks a shift in the focus of the narrative as, until this point, the narrative had been characterised by secrets and mystery
- The revelation serves as a catalyst for the climax of the novel:
  - It forces the narrator and Maxim to confront uncomfortable truths, which leads to a transformation of both of their characters
- The sunken boat is symbolic of the hidden truths and secrecy within Manderley

Key moment

Chapter 20
"She used to have this fellow Favell down to the cottage," said Maxim, "she would tell the servants she was going to sail, and would not be back before the morning. Then she would spend the night down there with him."

Summary of key moment:

- Maxim tells the second Mrs de Winter about the true nature of Rebecca and her affair with Jack Flavell

Why this is important in relation to the novel as a whole:

- Throughout most of the narrative, Rebecca has been idealised. However, these revelations disrupt the romanticised image of her:
  - It serves as a narrative climax and resolves the mystery which has surrounded Manderley
- This moment aligns with central themes of the novel such as identity, deception and the haunting influence of the past on the present:
  - It enables the narrator to challenge her preconceived notions about Rebecca and to question the image of Rebecca and her own self

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